

The Record North Shore

CASE STUDY | JANUARY TO MAY 2025

Background

The Record North Shore was founded in 2020 after the sudden and unexpected closing of 22nd Century Media, which operated newspapers in Chicago's North Shore.

Joe Coughlin and two other 22nd Century Media staff members decided to launch The Record North Shore, covering the communities of Wilmette, Winnetka, Northfield, Kenilworth and Glencoe through a daily website, weekly newsletters, podcasts and events.

Following a tragic shooting in Highland Park on July 4, 2022, Coughlin decided to add the community to its coverage area while watching the news, sitting at his kitchen table.

Coughlin along with Ryan Osborn, the director of development, have dedicated themselves to producing credible, courageous and community-first journalism — and sustaining it.

Highland Park was not on the original list of towns The Record North Shore covered. And while the decision to cover the community was born out of tragedy, there was never a concerted marketing effort or plan to expand there.

They relied completely on word-of-mouth marketing. Due to their inability to track hometowns for subscribers, they did not have a good handle on how many readers came from Highland Park. During the course of the project, they changed software systems to allow them to track where their readers lived.



Through the organization's participation in the Medill School of Journalism's Local News Accelerator (LNA), it later became clear both qualitatively and quantitatively that Highland Park residents want credible local coverage. In fact, the survey data showed that 57% of the 401 respondents want more local government coverage.

The "From/To/To" statement guiding the team's work was:

From	To	To (future)
Having a desire to expand coverage into Highland Park, but having little knowledge of readers' interests, habits and desired content, as well as how many current readers/paying members are from Highland Park.	Hired a new reporter to only cover Highland Park and produced more local government coverage, which The Record North Shore learned through research insights and acquiring 19 new paying members. The planned expansion into Highland Park also extended to Highwood, as a result of the research as well. Furthermore, the Highland Park/Highwood expansion positioned The Record to win \$150,000 in funding to expand into another underserved suburb, Skokie, through the Google News Initiative Growth Catalyst project	Developing a clear marketing plan for promoting The Record North Shore in the Highland Park area through the rest of 2025, such as movie nights, a partnership with NextDoor, FB spends, targeted email and hosting in-person coffees and chamber of commerce events.

Highlights

The organization set out to add 75 new Highland Park subscribers by the end of 2025.

As a result of the team's work during the LNA, they added 720 new newsletter subscribers. In addition, they garnered 80 new paying members, 20 of which come from Highland Park. They also held two events and hired a reporter to cover the towns of Highland Park and Highwood.

The LNA provided the team with the time and resources to deliberately expand their coverage and include this important community. Survey data from Northwestern confirmed they were on the right track — they simply needed to focus on spreading the word within the community.

The process

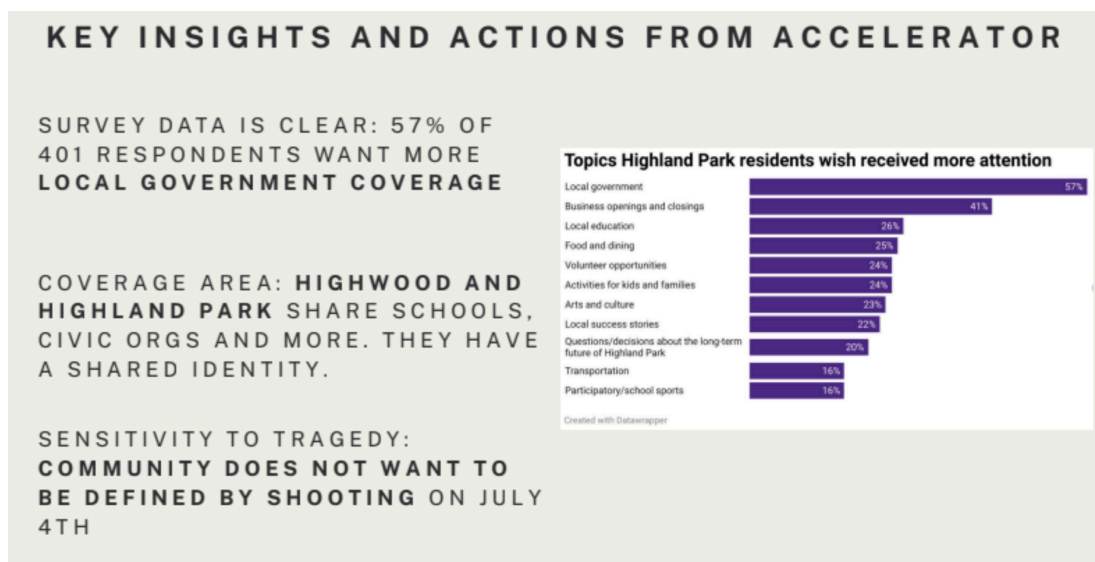
The goal of expanding into Highland Park and adding 75 new paying subscribers was the mission from Day 1 and did not change. This is an important market and one that clearly needed more attention and coverage.

The only shift in the strategy occurred after a reader focus group held in a local bookstore. Attendees were adamant that coverage needed to include the nearby town of Highwood. The communities are closely interrelated both geographically and historically. Though they are separate communities, they are essentially twin cities in many respects. (Highwood is surrounded by Highland Park on three sides.)

Research insights

Overall, the survey conducted by the Medill team validated that The Record North Shore is on the right track. The respondents were civic minded, deeply invested in their community and viewed local news sources as trustworthy. In other words, they want exactly what The Record produces.

Those surveyed consumed Highland Park news multiple times a week, with 98% of survey respondents saying they consume Highland Park news at least once a week. And, respondents demonstrated a relatively high level of trust, with 63% saying they trust local news to “get things right.”



Business strategies and tools

While all of the tools offered up by the LNA were helpful – each building on the last – the Business Model Canvas seemed to be the one that most clarified what needed to happen. It required the team to think deeply about each component of a business plan, and it became the basis for all the other tools.

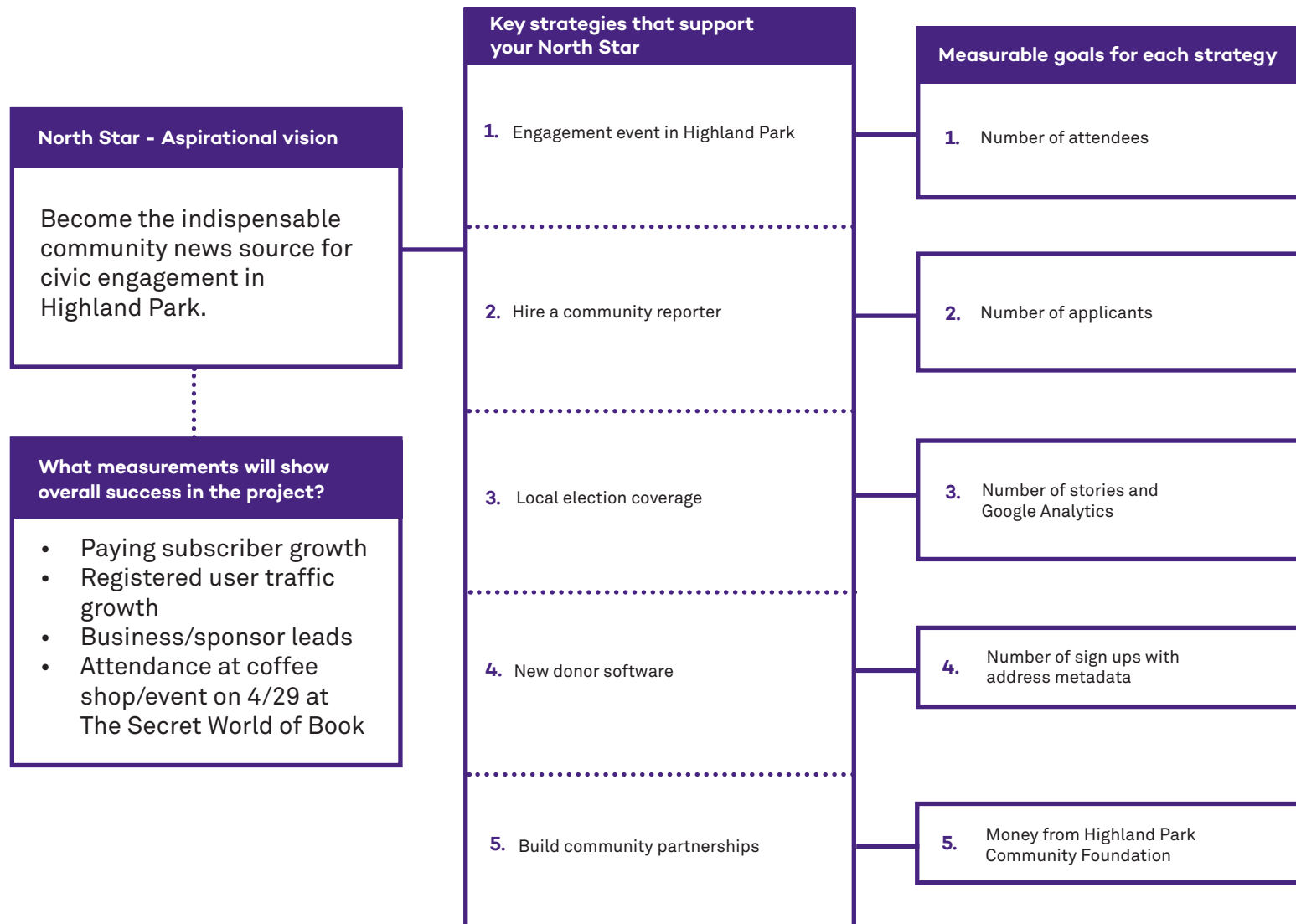
The Business Model Canvas:

- Clarified the From/To statement by building the customer value proposition; it also helped to create marketing personas.
- Informed who the product was designed for, who the partners are (and could be), as well as what the value proposition is. Without the value proposition, you cannot create a North Star.

Business Model Canvas

Customer segments	Civically engaged HP residents. Mistrustful community members. Younger parents with children in school.
Value propositions	Highland Park residents need regular, reliable information from a credible and responsible source. A traumatized community, they need/want thoughtful coverage that helps them move forward as a more cohesive community.
Channels	Email newsletters, social media (Facebook, Instagram, X), listening sessions (word of mouth)
Revenue streams	Reader revenue, sponsorship with local business community, major donors
Key resources	Content creation (another freelancer) - goal to produce 5-6 stories a week
Key activities	Meet with local leaders/influencers; targeted eblasts; website maintenance (tech); data collection (improve registration); experiment with different touchpoints
Key partners	Medill; board members; INN/LION/CIMA; civic organizations (rotary)
Cost structure	Tech (improve registration page); digital marketing; food/beverage (schmoozing); freelance

Three-part project statement



The Business Model Canvas is something The Record North Shore can use over and over again to ensure they are paying attention to all aspects of their business – and not just putting out the product/news.

The Three-Part Project Statement outlined the steps and specific goals for the Highland Park project.

Both models were indispensable.

The results

The Record North Shore saw 80 new members sign up at \$60 per year, equaling \$4,800 in new revenue. They also added 720 new readers to the top of the funnel as free newsletter subscribers.

Using a conversion rate of 12% (the average conversion rate the organization's had since its inception), The Record North Shore should see 86 new members by year's end, with 20 more from Highland Park by the end of December. That would equal 43 total new HP subscribers by year's end.

The additional revenue and readership allowed The Record North Shore to feel comfortable hiring a new reporter. Plus, the increased marketing in the area will help solidify its brand. They received a \$1,000 grant from the Highland Park Community Foundation and were awarded funding through the Google News Initiative Growth Catalyst project to continue its expansion into another suburb, Skokie.

The results demonstrate growth and have allowed The Record North Shore to see a way forward – both in terms of bolstering their current coverage areas, as well as expanding. The next target for them is Skokie, and the outcomes here have given them the blueprint they need to go forward.

A snapshot of The Record North Shore's wins

The chart below illustrates the wins The Record North Shore achieved throughout the LNA:

Process	Insight	Capability	Outcome
Prior to the LNA, The Record had no way to track where readers lived. During the program, they improved the data and CRM to enhance overall measurement. This improved the registration experience for readers; it also allows them to go to sponsors and funders with data about North Shore readers and their habits.	One of the biggest insights was discovered during the in-person event with readers. It was clear that residents of Highland Park feel a connection with the town of Highland Park and that The Record needs to devote time and coverage to that community. They also learned that marketing needs to be a key component to any expansion. They cannot rely on a "build it and they will come" mentality.	Confident the numbers will continue to grow, they felt comfortable with hiring a full-time Highland Park reporter.	• Added 20 new paying subscribers. • Added a reporter. • Developed a marketing strategy that will help them expand in other communities. • Secured \$150,000 in funding through the Google News Initiative Growth Catalyst project to expand into Skokie, another underserved suburb.

A Q&A



Eileen Brown, coach:

What was most helpful for your team in helping you achieve the goals you set at the start of the program?



Ryan Osborn, director of development:

We were able to build on valuable relationships with Tim Franklin, Mackenzie Warren, Yazmin Dominguez, our coach Eileen Brown and Darya Ushakova (Philadelphia Inquirer chief marketing officer who happens to live in our coverage area). They all were able to share unique feedback about our mission at The Record. The LNA also provided a unique opportunity to step back from the day-to-day grind and think more strategically about our goal of bringing credible local news back to Highland Park and Highwood.



Brown:

Did The Record North Shore have to pivot? If so, what led to the change?



Osborn:

We did not have to pivot during the program. Based on experience, we were able to set a tangible and realistic goal and were able to stay focused on responsibly expanding our coverage area to Highland Park and Highwood.



Brown:

What did you find the most surprising and/or challenging throughout the process?



Osborn:

It wasn't surprising, but the biggest challenge is always finding the time to unplug from our daily responsibilities. Every minute that we are not covering the news in the communities that we serve or spending time fundraising, we risk maintaining our audience and weekly budgets.



Brown:

How would other news organizations like your's benefit from participating in the LNA?



Osborn:

Other organizations would benefit to be in the same room as educators, coaches and colleagues who all understand the same challenges and be inspired by vital work happening despite industry headwinds.



Brown:

Where is The Record North Shore headed from here? What are the biggest lessons you learned through the LNA that you will apply to future projects?



Osborn:

We feel momentum and are energized to serve our communities. The biggest lesson is that as we expand, we must be more intentional about spreading the word and building our audience funnel.